

Jose Barbeito
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Essay on Reminiscence

“Tahiti is a magical place.” That is what Phil Coulson, senior agent of S.H.I.E.L.D. said, after being reminded of his time recovering from being stabbed in the heart by Loki’s magic spear. This happened in the first Avenger’s movie, but for anyone who watched the Agents of Shield TV show, the phrase is familiar. Why is this important? Phil Coulson actually died, and Shield spent seven days resurrecting him from the dead, during which he was put in extreme pain and unimaginable stress, to the point that he would beg the doctors to let him die. To help save Phil Coulson from the memory of his traumatic experience, the doctors replaced his memory of the procedure with pleasant memories of a vacation on the island of Tahiti. Later in the show, the reveal of his false memories causes a dramatic change in Phil’s view of life, and ends up causing more harm than good to him and his friends. I will argue that tampering and revisiting the past through memories is one the worst mistakes a person can make, and the movie Reminiscence (along with the TV show Agents of Shield) does exactly that. Alongside the moral implications, it connects heavily with Robert Nozick’s pleasure machine, and gives a perfect example of why the pleasure machine is a black hole for moral perfection.

The movie Reminiscence, made in 2021, follows a similar theme. After a massive world war, global warming, and ocean rise, the world retreats into a nocturnal, boat-filled life, the poor reduced to living on rafts while the rich build their own private islands. Nick Bannister, an ex-military interrogation officer, works with The Forge, a machine that allows people to relive past memories. Bannister helps the person within the machine, guiding them through the passageways of their mind, beginning with the memorable phrase, *“We’re going on a journey. A journey through memory. Your destination? A place and time you’ve been before.”* The movie

explores the importance of memories, and how we view them. Nick Bannister becomes addicted to the memories of a woman he loved, named Mae. After Mae disappears, Nick spends an increasing amount of time in The Forge, reliving the same moments again and again, his life slipping away into the past. When assisting the cops with a murder case in the real world, he finds that Mae is still alive, and that their entire relationship was fabricated. As Nick sets off to find her, he uses his memories as clues, each hint leading him into the right direction, following the clues in the real world. In the end, he finds the man who killed Mae, and in visiting his memories, finds a goodbye message left by Mae moments before her death, meant for Nick.

I know what you're thinking. Great movie summary, leave the review on Rotten Tomatoes, but how does this relate to anything real? Well, the themes and conclusions from the movie are good answers to Robert Nozick's Pleasure Machine thought experiment. Nozick proposed that if the ultimate goal of life was to be the happiest you could be, then the best thing for each person to do would be to be hooked up to a machine that simulates the best pleasures in life, allows our brains to be filled with chemical soup that brings nothing but pleasure and happiness. This is exactly what happens in *Reminiscence* - people decide to forgo the hardships of the real world and sink into the blissful memories of the past. Yet is this what we should be doing with our lives? Wasting away the moments living in a fake world, perceived only by our mind's eye? I would argue that we should not, and that doing so erodes the meaning of humanity and true happiness.

At first, the idea of the pleasure machine may seem appealing. After all, who wouldn't want to be able to have any experience they desire, without having to worry about the constraints of reality? But Nozick points out that there are some important drawbacks to the experience machine. For one, the person in the machine is not actually experiencing the things they think

they are experiencing. The experiences they have in the machine are not real, and are therefore not authentic. This lack of authenticity is at the heart of Nozick's critique of the experience machine. He argues that authenticity is an important part of human experience, and that we value our experiences in part because they are real and not simulated. In other words, we value the present moment because it is real and not just a simulation. I would argue the same, and so would Mae from *Reminiscence*, saying “*Maybe memory fades for a reason. If we just dwelled on the bad things in the past, we’d never get over them. And if we just dwelled on the good, we might never match it again.*” This lines up perfectly with Nozick’s views that simulated pleasures lack authenticity, and that the true importance of happiness is its hold on the real world.

In addition to the authenticity of happiness in the real world as compared to the simulated one, another point that *Reminiscence* argues is the duality of sadness and happiness, and how each makes the opposite all the more meaningful. At the end of the movie, Nick Bannister decides to spend the rest of his life in The Forge, living out his happiness in the past instead of making new memories in the present. Throughout the entire movie, Nick Bannister’s business partner, Emily, is shown to struggle with her failed motherhood, choosing to drink her problems away instead of searching for her daughter and caring for her. In the closing scene, Nick sits in The Forge, old and gray, as Emily returns with her granddaughter, showing her ability to return to her daughter and create a new relationship. Her granddaughter asks her why Bannister decided to waste his life away in the past, and she responds with a quote that points at the heart of the issue of the pleasure machine: “*Missing people is a part of living. Without that sadness, you can’t taste the sweet. A long time ago we both chose our endings. He turned back, and I chose ahead.*” Emily was the embodiment of looking towards the future, struggling through her hardship, and finding happiness on the other side, whereas Nick was the sad soul who gave up his life,

spending the time he had living in the past, reliving old memories. He warned that he would choose this earlier in the movie, ominously saying “*Between memory and oblivion, I know which torture I would choose.*”

The pleasure machine is a great thought experiment. It strikes at the idea that the only purpose of life is to be happy, a belief that I held for the longest time, until having to think about it this year. The movie *Reminiscence* (and others, such as *Agents of Shield*), show us that living false happiness is not true to life, and that there is no connection with any deeper reality when we experience happiness within Nozick’s pleasure machine. It is only through real experiences can we struggle through the troughs of despair and be truly happy on the other side. We as humans desire to *do* the things that are pleasurable, not only because they give us pleasure, but because we desire to see the outcomes of such actions. I know that I choose the pleasures of the present and future - real, tangible, and as unpredictable as the weather - than choose to live a life hooked up to a machine that is programmed to give me nothing but the most meaningless of pleasure. Nick Banister said it best in the closing scene of *Reminiscence*, saying “*The past doesn't haunt us, it wouldn't even recognize us. If there are ghosts to be found, it's us who haunt the past.*”